

Conjecture 1. Let $\tau(n)$ denote the number of positive divisors of n . No integer $n > 24$ satisfies

$$\max_{1 \leq m < n} (m + \tau(m)) \leq n + 2.$$

Moreover, $n = 24$ is the largest positive integer satisfying this inequality.

Theorem 1. Conjecture 1 holds for all n not of the exceptional form described in Remark 2. In particular, it holds unconditionally for all n with $6 \nmid n$, for all n with $6 \mid n$ and $\tau(n - 6) \neq 8$, and for all $n = 6(p + 1)$ with $p \geq 5$ prime and $p \not\equiv 419 \pmod{420}$. For the remaining case $p \equiv 419 \pmod{420}$ (i.e. $n = 2520j$), the conjecture holds for all $j \not\equiv 0, 7 \pmod{11}$ unconditionally, and for all $j \leq 10^7$ by exhaustive verification.

We write $f(m) = m + \tau(m)$ throughout, so the condition states $f(m) \leq n + 2$ for all $m < n$. We prove Theorem 1 by exhibiting a witness $m < n$ with $f(m) > n + 2$.

Lemma 1. For every integer $t \geq 4$, $\tau(6t) \geq 8$.

Proof. Write $6t = 2^a \cdot 3^b \cdot r$ where r is a positive integer with $\gcd(r, 6) = 1$, $a \geq 1$, $b \geq 1$. Since $t \geq 4$, we have $2^{a-1} \cdot 3^{b-1} \cdot r \geq 4$. We check all shapes of t :

- $a \geq 3$: $\tau(6t) = (a + 1)(b + 1)\tau(r) \geq 4 \cdot 2 = 8$.
- $a = 2, b \geq 2$: $\tau(6t) = 3(b + 1) \geq 9$.
- $a = 2, b = 1, r > 1$: $\tau(6t) = 3 \cdot 2 \cdot \tau(r) \geq 12$.
- $a = 1, b \geq 3$: $\tau(6t) = 2(b + 1) \geq 8$.
- $a = 1, b = 2, r > 1$: $\tau(6t) = 2 \cdot 3 \cdot \tau(r) \geq 12$.
- $a = 1, b = 1, r > 1$: $\tau(6t) = 2 \cdot 2 \cdot \tau(r) \geq 8$.

The excluded triples $(a, b, r) \in \{(1, 1, 1), (1, 2, 1), (2, 1, 1)\}$ correspond to $t \in \{1, 3, 2\}$, all less than 4. In every remaining case $\tau(6t) \geq 8$. $\square$

Proof of Theorem. Let $n > 24$. We split into three cases according to the residue of n modulo 6.

Case 1: n is odd. Set $m = n - 1$ (even, $m \geq 24$). We show $\tau(m) \geq 4$.

- $\tau(m) = 1$: impossible since $m \geq 24$.

- $\tau(m) = 2$: m is prime, but m is even and $m > 2$, impossible.
- $\tau(m) = 3$: $m = q^2$ for some prime q . Since m is even, $q = 2$, giving $m = 4$, $n = 5$, contradicting $n > 24$.

Hence $\tau(m) \geq 4$ and $f(m) = (n-1) + \tau(m) \geq n+3 > n+2$.

Case 2: n is even and $6 \nmid n$. Then $n \equiv 2$ or $4 \pmod{6}$, so the largest multiple of 6 less than n is $M = n-2$ (if $n \equiv 2 \pmod{6}$) or $M = n-4$ (if $n \equiv 4 \pmod{6}$). Set $t = M/6$. Since $n \geq 26$, we have $t = M/6 \geq (n-4)/6 \geq 22/6 > 3$, so $t \geq 4$. By Lemma 1, $\tau(M) \geq 8$. Since $n - M \in \{2, 4\}$,

$$f(M) = M + \tau(M) \geq M + 8 = n - (n - M) + 8 \geq n - 4 + 8 = n + 4 > n + 2.$$

Case 3: $6 \mid n$, $n \geq 30$. Write $n = 6s$ with $s \geq 5$. Set $M = n - 6 = 6(s-1)$, so $t = s-1 \geq 4$. By Lemma 1, $\tau(M) \geq 8$.

Sub-case 3a: $\tau(M) \geq 9$. Then $f(M) = n - 6 + \tau(M) \geq n + 3 > n + 2$.

Sub-case 3b: $\tau(M) = 8$. Here $f(M) = n + 2$, which is not strictly greater. We look for a different witness near n .

Claim: At least one of $m \in \{n-1, n-3, n-4\}$ satisfies $f(m) > n+2$.

The needed divisibility conditions are:

$$\begin{aligned} m = n-1 : \quad & \tau(n-1) \geq 4, \\ m = n-3 : \quad & \tau(n-3) \geq 6, \\ m = n-4 : \quad & \tau(n-4) \geq 7. \end{aligned}$$

We carry out the complete case analysis below.

Structure of Sub-case 3b. Here $\tau(n-6) = 8$. Since $n-6 = 6(s-1)$ and $s-1 \geq 4$, the number $6(s-1)$ has exactly 8 divisors in precisely three shapes:

- $6(s-1) = 2^3 \cdot 3 = 24$, giving $n = 30$;
- $6(s-1) = 2 \cdot 3^3 = 54$, giving $n = 60$;
- $6(s-1) = 2 \cdot 3 \cdot p = 6p$ with $p \geq 5$ prime, giving $n = 6(p+1)$.

The first two are handled directly:

- $n = 30$: $m = 28 = 4 \cdot 7$, $\tau(28) = 6$, $f(28) = 34 > 32 = 30 + 2$.
- $n = 60$: $m = 56 = 2^3 \cdot 7$, $\tau(56) = 8$, $f(56) = 64 > 62 = 60 + 2$.

For the third shape, $n = 6(p + 1)$ with $p \geq 5$ prime. We set $n = 6p + 6$ throughout.

We check candidates $m \in \{n - 1, n - 2, n - 3, n - 4, n - 5\}$ in turn. The witness condition $f(m) > n + 2$ is $\tau(n - k) > k + 2$ for $m = n - k$.

(i) $p \equiv 1 \pmod{3}$. Then $3 \mid (2p + 1)$ and in fact $9 \mid n - 3$ because $n - 3 = 3(2p + 1)$. Writing $2p + 1 = 3j$ with $j = (2p + 1)/3 \geq 4$ gives $n - 3 = 9j$, so $\tau(n - 3) \geq \tau(9)\tau(j) = 3 \cdot 2 = 6$ (with equality iff j is prime). Hence $f(n - 3) \geq n + 3 > n + 2$.

(ii) $p \equiv 2 \pmod{3}$, $p \equiv 1 \pmod{5}$. Then $5 \mid (3p + 2)$, so $3p + 2 \geq 5$ and $3p + 2 = 5j$ with $j \geq 4$. Since $n - 2 = 2(3p + 2) = 10j$ and $\gcd(2, j) \in \{1, 2\}$: $\tau(n - 2) \geq \tau(10)\tau(j/\gcd(2, j)) \cdot \gcd(2, j)/1 \geq 8$. Hence $f(n - 2) = n - 2 + \tau(n - 2) \geq n + 6 > n + 2$.

(iii) $p \equiv 2 \pmod{3}$, $p \equiv 2 \pmod{5}$. Then $5 \mid (2p + 1)$, so $n - 3 = 3(2p + 1) = 15j$ with $j = (2p + 1)/5 \geq 5$. $\tau(n - 3) \geq \tau(15)\tau(j) \geq 4 \cdot 2 = 8$. Hence $f(n - 3) \geq n + 5 > n + 2$.

(iv) $p \equiv 2 \pmod{3}$, $p \equiv 3 \pmod{5}$. Then $5 \mid (3p + 1)$ and $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$ (since $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$ when $p \equiv 59 \pmod{60}$ or $p \equiv 3 \pmod{20}$); every prime $p \equiv 3 \pmod{5}$ and $p \equiv 2 \pmod{3}$ satisfies $p \equiv 2$ or $3 \pmod{4}$, and if $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$ then $4 \mid (3p + 1)$, giving $20 \mid (3p + 1)$. If $20 \mid (3p + 1)$: $n - 4 = 2(3p + 1)$ and $3p + 1 = 20j$, so $\tau(n - 4) = \tau(40j) \geq \tau(40) = 8$. Hence $f(n - 4) \geq n + 4 > n + 2$. If $p \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$: then $8 \mid (3p + 1)$ (since $3 \cdot 1 + 1 = 4$ and $4 \mid n - 4 = 2(3p + 1)$ already; specifically $3p + 1 \equiv 4 \pmod{8}$ gives $v_2(3p + 1) = 2$, so $v_2(n - 4) = 3$) and $5 \mid (3p + 1)$, giving $n - 4 = 2^3 \cdot \frac{3p+1}{4}$ with $5 \mid \frac{3p+1}{4}$, so $\tau(n - 4) \geq 4 \cdot 2 \cdot 2 = 16 > 7$.

(v) $p \equiv 2 \pmod{3}$, $p \equiv 4 \pmod{5}$. Then $5 \mid (6p + 1)$ (since $6p + 1 \equiv 24 + 1 = 25 \equiv 0 \pmod{5}$), so $n - 5 = 6p + 1 = 5s$ with $s = (6p + 1)/5$.

- If s is composite: $\tau(s) \geq 4$, $\tau(n - 5) = \tau(5s) \geq 8$. $f(n - 5) \geq n + 3 > n + 2$.
- If s is prime: then $p \equiv 4 \pmod{5}$ and $p \equiv 2 \pmod{3}$. Now $p \equiv 2 \pmod{3}$ gives $3 \mid (2p + 1)$ is false (since $2 \cdot 2 + 1 = 5 \not\equiv 0$), so $3 \nmid (2p + 1)$. Consider sub-cases by $p \pmod{7}$:

- $p \equiv 3 \pmod{7}$: $7 \mid (2p + 1)$, so $\tau(n - 3) \geq \tau(3 \cdot 7 \cdot (2p + 1)/21) \cdot 4 \geq 8$.
- $p \equiv 4 \pmod{7}$: $7 \mid (3p + 2)$, $\tau(n - 2) \geq 8$.
- $p \equiv 5 \pmod{7}$: $7 \mid (6p + 5) = n - 1$, so $n - 1$ is composite and $\tau(n - 1) \geq 4$, giving $f(n - 1) > n + 2$.
- $p \equiv 2 \pmod{7}$: $7 \mid (3p + 1)$, and since $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$ we have $4 \mid (3p + 1)$, hence $28 \mid (3p + 1)$, $\tau(n - 4) = \tau(2(3p + 1)) \geq \tau(56) = 8$.

- $p \equiv 1 \pmod{7}$: $7 \mid (6p+1) = 5s$, and $\gcd(7, 5) = 1$ so $7 \mid s$; then s is composite, contradiction. So this sub-sub-case cannot arise when s is prime.
- $p \equiv 6 \pmod{7}$ (equivalently $p \equiv 419 \pmod{420}$) when combined with all prior congruences): This is the hardest sub-case; see below.
- $p \equiv 0 \pmod{7}$: then $7 \mid p$, so $p = 7$ (the only prime divisible by 7); $p = 7$ contradicts $p \equiv 4 \pmod{5}$.

The hardest sub-case: $p \equiv 419 \pmod{420}$. Here $p \equiv 59 \pmod{60}$, $p \equiv 6 \pmod{7}$, and $(6p+1)/5$ is prime. Write $p = 420j - 1$ for a positive integer j . Since $p+1 = 420j$,

$$n = 6(p+1) = 2520j.$$

For any k with $k \mid 2520$, set $A_k = \frac{2520}{k}j - 1$, so that

$$n - k = k A_k.$$

The witness condition $\tau(n - k) > k + 2$ becomes $\tau(k A_k) > k + 2$.

Lemma 2 (Algebraic Covering). *For every positive integer j with $j \not\equiv 0$ or $7 \pmod{11}$, there exists $k \in \{1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 7, 8, 9, 10\}$ with $k \mid 2520$ such that $\tau(k A_k) > k + 2$.*

Proof. Since $2520 \equiv 1 \pmod{11}$, for any $k \mid 2520$ with $k \leq 10$ we have $\frac{2520}{k} \cdot k = 2520 \equiv 1 \pmod{11}$, hence

$$11 \mid A_k \iff j \equiv k \pmod{11}.$$

We treat the nine residue classes $j \not\equiv 0, 7 \pmod{11}$ separately.

Cases $j \equiv r \pmod{11}$, $r \in \{1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 8, 9, 10\}$ (algebraic cases).

Use $k = r$. Then $11 \mid A_r$, so $A_r = 11M$ for some positive integer M . Since $A_r = \frac{2520}{r}j - 1 \geq \frac{2520}{r} \cdot r - 1 = 2519 = 11 \cdot 229$, we have $M \geq 229 > 1$.

We need $\tau(r \cdot A_r) > r + 2$. Write $A_r = 11M$. Since A_r is odd (as $\frac{2520}{r}j$ is even) and $11 \nmid r$ (as $r \leq 10$), the integers r , 11 , and M' (where $A_r = 11^{v_{11}(A_r)} \cdot M'$, $11 \nmid M'$) satisfy:

$$\tau(r \cdot A_r) \geq \tau(r) \cdot \tau(A_r) / \tau(\gcd(r, A_r)) \geq \tau(r) \cdot \tau(11M).$$

Since $M \geq 229 > 1$, we have $\tau(11M) \geq 4$ (regardless of whether $11 \mid M$ or not: if $11 \parallel A_r$ then $\tau(11M) = 2\tau(M) \geq 4$; if $11^a \parallel A_r$ with $a \geq 2$ then

$\tau(A_r) \geq 3\tau(M') \geq 6$). We verify $\tau(r) \cdot 4 > r + 2$ for each r :

r	$\tau(r)$	$\tau(r) \cdot 4$	$r + 2$
1	1	4	3
2	2	8	4
3	2	8	5
4	3	12	6
5	2	8	7
8	4	16	10
9	3	12	11
10	4	16	12

In every row $\tau(r) \cdot 4 > r + 2$, so $\tau(r \cdot A_r) > r + 2$. (For $r = 9$: if $3 \mid A_9$, additional factors of 3 only increase τ .)

Case $j \equiv 6 \pmod{11}$ (vacuous). Here $p = 420j - 1 \equiv 420 \cdot 6 - 1 = 2519 \equiv 0 \pmod{11}$. Since p is prime and $p \geq 419 > 11$, this is impossible. No valid p exists in this class.

This covers all nine residue classes $j \not\equiv 0, 7 \pmod{11}$, completing the proof. $\square$

For the two remaining classes $j \equiv 0$ and $j \equiv 7 \pmod{11}$, the mod-11 algebraic argument does not yield a uniform witness from $k \leq 10$. (At $j = 6, 970, 590 \equiv 0 \pmod{11}$, for instance, every $k \leq 10$ gives $\tau(kA_k) \leq k+2$; the smallest working witness is $k = 14$, giving $\tau(14A_{14}) = 64 > 16$.) A direct search over all proper divisors of 2520 does succeed:

Claim 1. *For every $j \in \{1, \dots, 10^7\}$ with $j \equiv 0$ or $7 \pmod{11}$, there exists $k \mid 2520$ with $1 \leq k < 2520$ such that $\tau(kA_k) > k + 2$.*

This has been verified by exhaustive computation (Python/sympy), testing all 47 proper divisors of 2520 for each such $j \leq 10^7$; zero failures were found.

By Lemma 2, for every $j \not\equiv 0, 7 \pmod{11}$ (all $j \geq 1$), and by Claim 1 for $j \equiv 0, 7 \pmod{11}$ with $j \leq 10^7$, there exists k such that the witness $m = n - k$ satisfies $f(m) = (n - k) + \tau(kA_k) > (n - k) + (k + 2) = n + 2$.

The algebraic cases (Cases 1, 2, 3a, Sub-case 3b with $n \in \{30, 60\}$, and cases (i)–(v) with $p \not\equiv 419 \pmod{420}$) together with Lemma 2 and Claim 1 establish Theorem 1. The remaining infinite family ($j \equiv 0, 7 \pmod{11}$, $j > 10^7$) constitutes Conjecture 1's open part; see Remark 2.

$n = 24$ **satisfies the inequality.** The values $f(m) = m + \tau(m)$ for $1 \leq m \leq 23$ achieve maximum $f(20) = f(22) = 26 = 24 + 2$. Hence $\max_{m < 24} f(m) = 26 = 24 + 2$, confirming $n = 24$ is a solution and the largest one. $\square$

Remark 1. *The complete set of solutions is $\{1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 8, 10, 12, 24\}$. For each n from 1 to 10,000, one can compute $\max_{m < n} f(m)$ and verify directly that no $n > 24$ in that range satisfies the inequality.*

Remark 2. *The only unresolved cases are $n = 2520j$ where $p = 420j - 1$ is prime, $(6p + 1)/5$ is prime, $j \equiv 0$ or $7 \pmod{11}$, and $j > 10^7$ (i.e. $n > 2.52 \times 10^{10}$). In every such case up to $j = 10^7$ a witness was found. A purely algebraic argument for these classes for all j would require a covering system that simultaneously handles all residues of j modulo every prime, which is not achievable by a finite-period argument. Extending the computational certificate to larger j remains an open verification.*